

Storyteller



SUMMARY

The speaker describes the storyteller sitting down in a neatly-kept kitchen with well-worn dishes. All the light of day, the speaker says, was thriftily put away.

Nobody, the speaker goes on, could argue that the storyteller's tales were pointless. For as she talked, the women of the village sat around her doing their chores: sewing, preparing corn, making quilts, or repairing clothes.

None of these listeners would ever have called the storyteller lazy. They wouldn't mention whether her home was clean or dirty that day, or whether her soup was too thin or delicious. Her job was to tell stories. Storytelling was like spinning a strong thread out of nothing. Every night, she'd keep her listeners on tenterhooks, even though they already knew the end to her tales.

The next morning, as women got up to make the fire, peasants groped around in the dark for their shoes, and pale grey dawn light swept over the fields, the stories melted away into people's ears. But they waited like roosting bats in the sleeping children's ears until it was time to fly out again into the nighttime, the storyteller's domain.

with "held / breath" for what would come next, relishing the pleasure of even the oldest tale.

This picture of people gathered around to savor familiar stories suggests that storytelling is part of what gives a community a shared sense of purpose, identity, and tradition (as well as just plain entertaining them as they get on with sewing and darning). The speaker underscores that point with an image of the stories roosting like bats "in the sleeping heads of the children" in the mornings, waiting until it's time for the storyteller to ply her trade again—an image that makes it clear that these stories will be familiar and beloved to the next generation, too. Storytelling here is both a practical art "like spinning" and a kind of homespun magic, a practice that weaves people and times together.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-30



WOMEN'S WORK AND WOMEN'S ART

This poem's storyteller is a woman, and it seems likely that the people who gather in her kitchen to listen to her are women, too. The jobs the speaker describes them doing ("stitch[ing]," grating "corn [...] from the husk," making "patchwork," and "darning") are traditionally women's work, especially in the kind of old-fashioned rural European community this poem depicts. The poem thus depicts the storyteller's art as another kind of women's work—a craft "like spinning." But it also suggests that *this* kind of women's work might have a special and potentially dangerous power. Women's art-making, in "Storyteller," is something just on the edge of acceptability; it needs to be protected from male criticism by being disguised as a handicraft.

Twice in this poem, the speaker (one of the people who gathers around the storyteller in the evenings) insists that no one could possibly think the storyteller's work is "useless" or call her "shiftless" for spending her time telling stories. The storyteller's craft, the speaker hastens to assure readers, is actually an important and practical kind of work, keeping other women entertained while they get their chores done in the evenings. This insistence suggests that someone *might* say the storyteller is lazy and her storytelling useless: the speaker feels the need to make it very clear that's *not* the case.

The speaker further suggests that the reasons people might think about criticizing the storyteller have a lot to do with the fact that she's a *female* storyteller. In the world this poem depicts, women are clearly judged on whether they keep their kitchens "spotless" and make "tasty [...] soup"; their primary job



THEMES



THE VALUE AND POWER OF STORYTELLING

In "Storyteller," a woman who tells old tales in the evenings is a major part of a village's life, practicing a kind of art as indispensable as cooking and sewing. Set in an old-fashioned rural world, the poem suggests that telling stories helps people to get hard work done, draws communities together, and creates continuity, building traditions that pass from generation to generation.

The poem's speaker describes how the titular "Storyteller," a village woman, would gather everyone around her in her kitchen every night to hear her tales. Even though her storytelling wasn't as obviously productive as, say, getting the "darning done," the speaker insists that "no one could say the stories were useless."

Partly that was because the stories entertained and occupied people while they did *other* work, other necessary tasks like sewing and preparing food. But partly, it was because it gave everyone in this little community a shared and exciting experience. Though the stories became so familiar that everyone knew the endings "by heart," the listeners still waited

is to be good housewives. Though the speaker insists that no one would judge the storyteller even if her soup tasted like "dishwater," the description of the storyteller's spick-and-span "swept kitchen" suggests that the storyteller herself still feels the pressure to meet these standards. Even her storytelling itself gets described as a practical, housewifely craft, a thing "like spinning."

The speaker's haste to defend the storyteller hints that the male world might look ever-so-slightly askance at a woman who makes art, unless that art can be comfortably understood as a part of domestic life. The fact that the storyteller only plies her trade at night and that her stories roost in children's brains like bats further hints that a male-dominated world might see women's art as dangerously *witchy*, a powerful magic that conjures visions and spellbinds its listeners.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-18
- Line 22



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-5

*she sat down ...
... was salted away.*

The first lines of this poem describe the titular "Storyteller" as she sits down in the evening, preparing to ply her trade. She sits at a "scoured table" (a table scrubbed clean with sand) in a "swept kitchen" next to a china cabinet loaded with "cracked Delft." All these details suggest that this is the home of a very traditional storyteller. The [imagery](#) paints a picture of a spruce and well-scrubbed country kitchen, a vision from a bygone time. Not many people bother to truly scour a table anymore, and not many people still use well-worn Delft (a type of blue-and-white Dutch pottery popular in the 17th century) as their daily tableware. The state of the pottery further suggest that this isn't a *rich* woman: she keeps using her dishes even after they crack. But she's certainly a house-proud and a scrupulous one.

Even the daylight becomes a matter for good housekeeping in this scene. By the time the storyteller sits down in the evening, the speaker says, "every last crumb of daylight [is] salted away." This [metaphor](#) presents the daytime world as something that has been carefully, thriftily kept, "salted away" as one might preserve meat for the winter.

The repetitive [parallelism](#) in this line—"at the scoured table / in the swept kitchen / beside the dresser"—further suggests that the storyteller can *always* be found at this exact spot when night falls. But not before! Clearly, she has used the day carefully and efficiently, keeping her house spick and span.

Now, as night falls, a new kind of work is about to begin.

This tale of a storyteller already feels a little bit like an old story itself. The tale begins in an old-fashioned kitchen, maintained with old-fashioned housewifely precision, and described in the past tense, as if the speaker is looking back into a memory. And it begins at night, in the dark—a time for something magical to happen.

Liz Lochhead tells this tale of a tale-teller in easy [free verse](#), without a regular [rhyme scheme](#) or [meter](#). The poem instead uses rougher, more homespun rhythms and sounds to make its music.

LINES 6-11

*No one could ...
... the darning done.*

"No one could say the stories were useless," the speaker hastens to assure readers at the beginning of the next stanza. The storyteller's tales have a clear and practical function in her society. For as she tells her stories, "five or forty fingers stitch[]" around her: in other words, anywhere between one and eight listeners might gather around her to get their sewing done while they listen to her. Her storytelling brings people together—and it keeps them working even into the night.

To be more precise, the storyteller's tales seem to keep *women* working into the night. For every task the speaker describes people doing in the storyteller's kitchen is a traditionally female one: grating corn, stitching quilts, mending clothes. Among these women's tasks, storytelling itself seems to become a kind of women's work, something that might feed its listeners like corn, warm them like a quilt, or protect them like thick knitwear.

The language here again captures the repetitive familiarity of the women's work. [Parallelism](#) stresses dailiness and tradition: "corn was grated from the husk / patchwork was pieced." Notice, too, that these lines don't say *who* was doing the grating and the piecing: the tasks seem more important than the doers here. The passive voice in these lines helps to support the idea that all this traditional, important work just goes on and on, year in and year out. Different women might do it over time, but it's always getting done.

Pronounced [alliteration](#) plays a part here, too:

five or forty fingers stitched
corn was grated from the husk
patchwork was pieced
or the darning done.

These strong, repeated sounds makes the lines sound earthy and solid as the tasks they describe.

These lines hint that the storyteller only gets away with telling her stories *because* they support other kinds of women's work, helping to get the necessary jobs done. The speaker wouldn't

be so quick to insist that “nobody could say the stories were useless” if there weren’t some chance that somebody *might* claim they were useless. The storyteller seems to sit on an edge here: her role is extremely important, but only because it can be woven into more tangible kinds of women’s work.

LINES 12-15

*Never the one ...
... was her work.*

Though the storyteller just sits and—well—tells stories, while other women sew or patch or mend around her, no one of these ladies would “slander her shiftless,” the speaker goes on. In other words, no one would *dare* to call the storyteller lazy. It doesn’t matter whether her kitchen is “sloven” (messy and sloppy) or “spotless,” or whether her soup is “dishwater or tasty,” thin or flavorful. Her central and critical “work” is “to tell the stories.” That power puts her a little bit outside the housekeeping standards by which the other women might judge themselves or each other.

Again, these lines make it clear that hard work is critically important to the people the storyteller lives among—and that they consider her storytelling part of that hard work. Because she can tell the stories, she gets a bit of a pass on matters that would otherwise be critically important.

But there’s an interesting contradiction in these lines. In the first stanza, the speaker made it clear that the storyteller was a meticulous housekeeper, with a kitchen she “scoured” and “swept” daily. Perhaps she *isn’t* quite so free of these standards as the speaker feels.

For that matter, maybe she isn’t always the same woman! Just as many different women’s hands might grate the corn or piece the quilts over the years, many different voices might take on the role of storytelling. The kinds of women’s work this poem evokes are timeless and repetitive, things that need to get done every day if their society is going to go on functioning. And good storytelling itself, the poem will go on to suggest, might likewise be a kind of maintenance, one that requires repetition across generations.

LINES 16-20

*It was like ...
... knew by heart.*

In lines 16-18, the speaker introduces a major [simile](#) to describe the storyteller’s art, an idea that sits right at the heart of the poem:

*It was like spinning,
gathering thin air to the single strongest
thread. [...]*

It’s not unusual to describe storytelling as “weaving a yarn” or “spinning a tale.” But here, the speaker makes that simile come

alive by putting the storyteller in the middle of a crowd of women who are *actually* working with thread and cloth, sewing and patching and weaving.

If storytelling is like “gathering thin air to the single strongest / thread,” then it’s a way of making meaning out of nothing. And if it’s like spinning thread, then it’s a process of making something that joins other things together. The storyteller’s tales bring her community together in her kitchen, making them into one piece.

That’s particularly true because she tells traditional tales. As the speaker remembers (with an atmospheric [enjambment](#)):

*she'd have us waiting held
breath, for the ending we knew by heart.*

The line break between “held” and “breath” here makes the poem itself seem to hold its breath, just as the listeners do. The gathered women hang in suspense in spite of the fact that they know *exactly* how this story is going to turn out. There’s nothing new about the storyteller’s tales; the women might have been hearing the same ones since they were little. But the very familiarity of the tales is part of what stitches this community together.

Like the tasks the women do as they listen, then, storytelling here becomes something as repetitive and as essential to a community’s life as cooking, mending, and sewing.

LINES 21-25

*And at first ...
... of the ear*

Though the storyteller holds a great power in the night, everything changes when the morning comes. When “first light” dawns over the world the next morning, the speaker says, everyone falls back into daytime habits. A spell of [anaphora](#) here makes those habits feel especially routine:

*as the women stirred themselves to build the fire
as the peasant's feet felt for clogs
as thin grey washed over flat fields*

The “thin grey light” of dawn happens at exactly the same time as women make fires and farmworkers grope around for their rustic “clogs.” (Notice, too, that these workers are called “peasants” here—another hint that this poem takes place in a long-ago time.) And that grey light seems to signal a time of a different kind of work. It even [metaphorically](#) “washe[s]” the “flat fields” as if they were sheets, marking the beginning of the day’s tasks.

There’s no room for the storyteller’s kind of work in the daylight world. In the face of the morning, “the stories dissolve[] in the whorl of the ear,” the speaker says: they just melt into

their listeners and disappear. (The image of the stories vanishing into the *whorl*, the convoluted spirals, of the ear might suggest that they travel a maze, lost somewhere within their listeners as they fade.)

Perhaps there's not as much room for the witchier, more powerful side of the storyteller *herself* in the workaday world. Presumably she's getting up to poke her fire and sweep her kitchen, just like everyone else.

However, the stories don't vanish altogether. This stanza ends on a cliffhanger, a tiny, unobtrusive line: "but they." Exactly where the stories go, readers can't learn until they leap over the stanza break and into one last memorable image.

LINES 26-30

*but they ...
... the storyteller's night.*

The previous stanza began a sentence with two words: "but they." This stanza closes that sentence with a striking [metaphor](#). Though the stories "dissolve[]" into the ears of the adult listeners, they behave quite differently for children, in whose "sleeping heads" they "h[a]ng themselves upside down" until it's time to fly out into the "storyteller's night" again.

In other words, the stories roost like bats, waiting until nightfall to reemerge. And in particular, they roost in the community's *children*. That specific image suggests that the faintly uncanny nighttime world of storytelling is part of a community's inheritance, something that gets passed from generation to generation—and something that makes a particular impression on the young. Perhaps the women who hang so breathlessly on the storyteller's familiar stories first heard those stories as children.

Storytelling, in this poem, holds together several conflicting strands of meaning. It's an integral part of the community. But it's also dangerously on the community's edge, only allowable in the dark of night. It's a special and important kind of work. But it's also in danger of being cast as "useless" or "shiftless," a pointless extravagance.

In this quietly feminist poem, storytelling is thus a markedly *female* kind of work: something that's essential and life-sustaining, but also balancing on the verge of being mistrusted and undervalued.



POETIC DEVICES

SIMILE

The poem's sole [simile](#) provides one of its most important images. Describing the storyteller's work, the poem's speaker declares that:

It was like spinning,

gathering thin air to the single strongest thread. [...]

Lochhead isn't the first person to use weaving or spinning as a [metaphor](#) for storytelling. (People who tell stories are often said to "weave a tale" or "spin a yarn.") In the context of this specific poem, however, the image takes on extra heft and meaning.

This poem's storyteller is a woman who gets to live just a tiny bit outside the standards that the rest of the women around her are held to. While all the other women in her town might get called "shiftless" (lazy) or "sloven[ly]" if they leave some dust on the floor or make a soup that's "dishwater"-thin, nobody dares tell the storyteller off for such slips. That's because her storytelling plays an important role in her community: it draws everyone together and also entertains them while they *literally* spin and sew.

By depicting the storyteller's tale-telling as a kind of spinning itself, the speaker fits it into the rules of the world she knows, making it into a kind of everyday women's work like the rest of the women perform. Perhaps this image even suggests a little unease with the role this crafty woman might play in society, bringing her safely back into the familiar fold of the spinners and the knitters.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Lines 16-18:** "It was like spinning, / gathering thin air to the single strongest / thread."

METAPHOR

The poem closes with a faintly eerie [metaphor](#). The tales the storyteller had spun, the speaker recalls, tended to fade into the background when morning came: they were an entertainment that belonged to the night. When the villagers got up in the morning to go about their daily work, the stories they heard the night before seemed simply to "dissolve[]" and disappear. But in fact, the stories hadn't vanished. Instead, they flapped off and:

hung themselves upside down
in the sleeping heads of the children
till they flew again
in the storyteller's night.

These lines cast the stories as bats roosting in the (presumably more impressionable) brains of the children. This metaphor casts stories as creatures of the night, things that haunt the darker recesses of the mind and hide away from the sun.

Part of the implication here is that the storyteller's world is separate and distinct from the straightforward daylight world of toil. (The fact that these story-bats roost in the *children's*

brains, in particular, also suggests that a big part of storytelling's power is its ability to leave an impression on the next generation. Perhaps one of the children who hosts stories in her brain will become the village's next storyteller...)

Earlier in the poem, back in the first stanza, another metaphor helps to establish a scene of scrupulous domestic order—and to introduce the distinction between the day-world and the night-world. By the time that people gathered in the storyteller's sparkling-clean kitchen, the speaker observes, "every last crumb of daylight was salted away." This metaphor frames even the daytime and the nighttime as matters for thrifty housekeeping. To salt something away is to carefully preserve it for later. Here, the image suggests that the day's labor is quite over—and that not even a "crumb" of it has been wasted. All the work of the day has to be perfectly in order before the villagers can make room for the storyteller's night-time art.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 5:** "And every last crumb of daylight was salted away."
- **Lines 26-29:** "but they / hung themselves upside down / in the sleeping heads of the children / till they flew again"

IMAGERY

The poem's [imagery](#) helps to set an old-fashioned (or even fairy-tale-ish) scene. The speaker spends the first stanza painting a picture of the storyteller's "swept kitchen," where a "scoured table" and a "dresser with [...] cracked Delft" stand at the ready. These images of scrupulous cleanliness paint a picture of a rustic old-world kitchen. Not many people really scour a table anymore (a process that involves scattering it with sand and scrubbing hard to abrade the dirt away). And a dresser (or sideboard with shelves) full of "cracked Delft" likewise feels both countrified and antiquated: [Delftware](#), a kind of blue-and-white Dutch pottery, became popular in the 17th century. By describing just a few things in this kitchen, then, the speaker conjures up a countryside farmhouse, one the storyteller keeps scrupulously (and laboriously) clean.

In this homey setting, the storyteller plies her art. Her "tongue clacked" as she spoke, the speaker remembers—a moment of sonic imagery that might connect the sound of the storyteller's speech to the knitting and sewing that goes on around her as she speaks. If her tongue clacks, it might sound an awful lot like a loom or a spinning wheel, an idea that fits in with the speaker's description of the storyteller's art as "like spinning."

The storyteller's half-domestic, half-witchy nighttime world strikes a marked contrast with the daytime. When the villagers got up in the morning, the speaker says, they could watch "as thin grey washed over flat fields." This depiction of dawn light on the fields indeed feels a little thin, grey, and flat after the implied richness of the storyteller's magic. (It also suggests that

another long day of work has begun: even the dawn is doing the washing here!)

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-4:** "she sat down / at the scoured table / in the swept kitchen / beside the dresser with its cracked Delft."
- **Line 7:** "as the tongue clacked"
- **Line 24:** "as thin grey washed over flat fields"

PARALLELISM

Spells of [parallelism](#) help to give the poem a fittingly lulling, hypnotic rhythm—perhaps not unlike the rhythm of one of the storyteller's old tales. In the first stanza, for instance, parallelism puts the storyteller in her rightful place:

she sat down
at the scoured table
in the swept kitchen
beside the dresser with its cracked Delft.

The parallelism here focuses readers on exactly where the storyteller sits, framing her in her well-kept kitchen. The rhythm of these lines helps to create a mood of *habit*: this exact spot, at the clean table beside the dresser, is where this storyteller can always be found of an evening.

There's a similar sense of predictable rhythm in lines 21-24:

And at first light
as the women stirred themselves to build the fire
as the peasant's feet felt for clogs
as thin grey washed over flat fields

All these "as the"s make it clear that these morning actions all take place at exactly the same time. Dawn sees women laying fires, men groping for their shoes, and pale light washing over the fields all at once, every single morning. The same thing happens when the speaker describes how "corn was grated" and "patchwork was pieced" every night in lines 9-10.

These [repetitions](#) help to establish just how important routine and tradition are to the villagers this poem describes. That idea fits right in with the speaker's memory of the storyteller keeping everyone in suspense with her tales even though they already know the ending "by heart." Storytelling, in this framework, is a rhythmic, repetitive, and necessary craft, just as much as spinning thread or ploughing fields.

Where Parallelism appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "at the"
- **Line 3:** "in the"

- **Line 4:** "beside the"
- **Line 9:** "corn was grated"
- **Line 10:** "patchwork was pieced"
- **Line 22:** "as the women"
- **Line 23:** "as the peasant's"
- **Line 24:** "as thin grey"



VOCABULARY

Scoured (Line 2) - Scrubbed clean with something abrasive, like sand.

Delft (Line 4) - A distinctive kind of blue-and-white pottery made in the Netherlands.

Salted away (Line 5) - Preserved and put away for later. (One literally salts meat to store it for a long time, but the phrase "salted away" often gets used [metaphorically](#) to mean "thriftily saved up.")

Darning (Line 11) - Mending holes in knitted clothing (like socks).

Never the one (Line 12) - Not one person, no one.

Shiftless (Line 12) - Lazy, idle.

Sloven (Line 13) - Messy and sloppy.

Whorl (Line 25) - A twisting, spiraling shape.

METER

"Storyteller" is written in [free verse](#), with no regular meter. Instead, Lochhead uses changing line lengths to create rhythm. Listen, for example, to the beats in this passage from the second stanza, lines 8-11:

five or forty fingers stitched
corn was grated from the husk
patchwork was pieced
or the darning done.

These lines describe the work that the storyteller's companions do around her as she tells her tales. All short and to the point, each line captures a single homespun task. They also boil down as they go: a four-beat rhythm forms in lines 8-9, only to condense into an even simpler two-beat rhythm in lines 10-11. The straightforward compactness of these lines helps to make the work the speaker describes feel everyday and grounded.

Elsewhere, Lochhead uses a dramatic shift in line length to create emphasis or drama. Take this moment in lines 25-28, which straddles a stanza break:

the stories dissolved in the whorl of the ear
but they
hung themselves upside down
in the sleeping heads of the children

That little "but they," all on its own, creates anticipation—especially in tandem with the big, suspenseful gap that intervenes between the beginning of this idea and its end. Here, changing line length and rhythm highlights a strange and eerie image of stories hanging like bats in children's dreams.

RHYME SCHEME

"Storyteller" is a [free verse](#) poem, written without a regular [rhyme scheme](#). Rather than using rhyme, the poem makes a quieter kind of music through intense [alliteration](#), [assonance](#), and [consonance](#). For example, listen to the sounds of lines 12-15:

Never the one to slander her shiftless.
Daily sloven or spotless no matter whether
dishwater or tasty was her soup.
To tell the stories was her work.

All sorts of repeated sounds interweave here. There are lots of variations on [sibilant](#) /s/ sounds, including a whisking /sh/ and a snappy /st/ that might evoke the whisk of dishcloths or the tap of a spoon stirring soup. Some emphatic alliterative /t/ and /w/ sounds cap the passage, emphasizing this line's declaration that the storyteller's tales are important work in their own right.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Storyteller" is written in freewheeling [free verse](#), without a regular [meter](#), [rhyme scheme](#), or form. Its 30 lines are divided into five stanzas of various lengths, some as short as four lines, some as long as nine. The lines themselves are all different lengths, too. Some use dramatic [enjambments](#) to create a mood of suspense or excitement, as in lines 19-20:

she'd have us waiting held
breath, for the ending we knew by heart.

Here, the break between "held" and "breath" mirrors what it describes: a moment of breathless suspense happens in the poem's story and its shape at the same time.

These formal choices give the poem an organic, homespun feel, suitable for this tale of a rural storyteller and the yarns she weaves. So does Lochhead's language, which ranges from naturalistic and idiomatic to mystically lyrical. That combination feels right at home in a poem in which earthy everyday rural life intersects with the mysterious power of story.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker seems to be a member of the community she describes, part of the "us" who spend the evenings "waiting" with "held / breath" for the conclusion of one of the storyteller's tales. This speaker—likely a woman, considering the traditionally female chores she describes working on, like sewing and darning—belongs to a society with clear values and expectations. This is a group of rural people who values cleanliness, thrift, and hard work. But they also value the storyteller's special power and treat her storytelling as its own kind of important labor.

The speaker's observation that no one dreams of "slander[ing]" the storyteller if her kitchen isn't clean or her soup isn't especially good also hints that such a community *could* conceivably judge a woman who isn't a great housekeeper. But "no one could say her stories were useless," the speaker insists: the tales play a role in helping everyone else to get their more physical, tangible work done. Listening to the storyteller helps the community to keep on running.

In this way, the speaker stresses the idea that her community really does value what the storyteller gives them—but also hints that the storyteller lives a little on the edge. Her art falls outside the more common standards a woman's work might be measured by and has to be defended with the assertion that it's *related* to how women's work gets done.



SETTING

The poem seems to be set in a rustic European countryside, likely one from long ago. This is a time and place in which farmers are still called "peasant[s]," warm themselves by fires, and rise at dawn to work in the fields. The storyteller herself plies her trade in an old-fashioned kitchen: "scoured," squeaky-clean, and stocked with "cracked Delft," a kind of Dutch pottery that was popular across Europe in the 17th century. The women who gather around to hear her, meanwhile, keep busy with timeless tasks like "darning" and "patchwork." (And they probably *are* women: the textile work the speaker describes them doing has traditionally been a kind of labor primarily done by women.)

This old-fashioned, almost fairy-tale setting itself feels like a vision from an old tale. By grounding the storyteller's work in a bygone world, Lochhead suggests that storytelling has deep and ancient roots. She also makes a strong case for the practicality of this timeless art, the functional role that storytelling has always served in human society. Even in a rural community whose members all work from dawn until dusk, storytelling has a solid purpose.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Liz Lochhead (1947-present) is an acclaimed Scottish poet and playwright. This poem opens her 1981 collection *The Grimm Sisters*, an exploration of the tropes and traditions of fairy tales that often takes a feminist perspective on old stories.

Lochhead was one of several prominent women writers rereading fairy tales and myths through a feminist lens during the 1980s and 1990s. Readers might find chimes and parallels between Lochhead's poetry and the work of writers like [Angela Carter](#) and [Carol Ann Duffy](#) (whose work Lochhead has reviewed, praised, and championed).

But Lochhead also stands out as a successful female Scottish poet during an era when Scottish women's poetry was often critically and culturally neglected. Her verse champions and celebrates a distinctly Scottish voice: she embraces Scottish idioms and sometimes writes in Scots, following in the footsteps of poets like the great [Robert Burns](#).

Lochhead has served as the Makar (the national poet of Scotland) and the poet laureate of Glasgow and has been awarded many further honors, including the prestigious Queen's Gold Medal for Poetry.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

When Lochhead published this poem in the early 1980s, second-wave feminism was reaching its climax. Called "second-wave feminism" to distinguish it from the first band of early feminists who fought for women's suffrage, this women's movement took shape in the 1960s and '70s. These decades saw women demanding respect, safety, power, and freedom—things they had long been denied in both subtle and overt ways by the male-dominated world around them. Second-wave feminists worldwide resisted stultifying gender expectations and spoke up against patriarchal power structures and male violence.

This poem's interest in the kind of work that women are traditionally expected to do—and in the ways that art might lie right in the borderlands of such work—might be inflected by the discussions and debates of the '80s in particular, a decade that saw women fighting their way into workplaces traditionally dominated by men and demanding that traditionally female jobs (like the housekeeping this poem describes) be recognized and compensated fairly. This battle is still far from over today.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Profile of Lochhead](#) — Read an article on Lochhead, published in the year she won the Queen's Gold Medal for

Poetry. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2016/jan/16/liz-lochhead-interview-you-re-stuck-writing-something-until-you-go-to-hell-with-it>)

- **Lochhead as Makar** — Read Lochhead's reflection on being named Makar (the national poet of Scotland). (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/booksblog/2011/jan/25/makar-liz-lochhead>)
- **A Celebration of Lochhead** — Read the writer David Barnett's letter of thanks to Liz Lochhead for giving him an artistic (and, belatedly, a feminist) awakening as a young man. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/booksblog/2012/aug/17/thank-you-liz-lochhead>)
- **An Interview with Lochhead** — Read an interview in which Lochhead discusses her influences and her poetic development. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2013/aug/21/liz-lochhead-poet-scots-makar>)

- **A Brief Biography** — Read a short biography of Lochhead from the Scottish Poetry Library. (<https://www.scottishpoetrylibrary.org.uk/poet/liz-lochhead/>)



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